

Working with Underscore JavaScript Templates

This article is targeted at front-end developers and takes the reader on a tour of Underscore.js, which is an easy-to-learn JavaScript library.

UNDERSCORE.JS



Web based applications are very popular due to cross-platform support. They also don't need any software to be installed on the client side due to the versatility of the browsers.

A decade ago, we had limitations on client-side processing power. So we set up high-end servers, produced most of the HTML content on the server side and sent it to the client. We kept all the logic including HTML generation on the server side. On the client side, we just used JavaScript to validate the user's inputs.

Things changed over a period of years. The processing power of the client increased rapidly. At the same time, the amount of client-side code also increased. In other words, part of the processing was moved from the server to the client.

Now, it is common to see JS files with more than 1000 lines of code. A larger number of lines obviously increases complexity. To keep the code simple and readable, there is need for a structure or design patterns. We now see many frameworks doing this job. For example, BackboneJS, AngularJS and EmberJS are very popular JS frameworks.

In client-side programming, separating the view generation part is most important in order to reduce code complexity and improve code readability. Many template engines are available to handle the view part, e.g., Underscore.js, Handlebars.js, Jade.js, dust.js, Mustache.js,...

Among these JS templates, Underscore.js is very simple and easy to learn.

Underscore.js

Underscore.js is a JavaScript library. It has a number of useful functions to make life easy. This library was created by Jeremy Ashkenas. He is the creator of the CoffeeScript programming language, the Backbone.js

JavaScript framework, and the Underscore.js JavaScript library. Currently, many developers are contributing to the Underscore.js library. It is open source and the latest available version is 1.8.3.

The site <http://underscorejs.org> provides the complete list of functions available with Underscore.js. The `_.template` is one of the functions that provides template features.

This library is a hard dependency for the BackboneJS framework. If you currently use the Backbone framework in your project, it means you already have Underscore.js and you can use its functions. So we can say that, by default, the Backbone framework uses Underscore as a template solution.

Installation

You can install Underscore by using a JavaScript package manager such as Bower, npm, Meteor or Component.js by the following methods:

Node.js

```
npm install underscore
```

Meteor.js

```
meteor add underscore
```

Bower

```
bower install underscore
```

Component.js

```
component install jashkenas/underscore
```